



ShabbaTTogether

@Home Sermon Parshat Mishpatim

This upcoming Shabbat is celebrated worldwide as *ShabbaTTogether*, a time to re-embrace the value of each individual, with an emphasis on people with disabilities and mental health conditions. Each person is ultimately precious in the eyes of the Creator, who designs our unique abilities and disabilities in correlation to our unique individual missions in life.

That jives with this week's Torah portion, *Mishpatim*, which uses a set of civil laws to guide *attitudes*—particularly the need to identify with the sensitivities of others, and especially of the vulnerable. Such concepts were innovative in ancient times, and set in motion humanity's gradual evolution of social sensitivity and justice. It is our duty to progress in these areas.

The Covid pandemic brought isolation, interruption to life and commerce, breakdown in socialization, illness, loss, uncertainties, mental strain, anxiety, depression, PTSD, and other trauma and stress-related disorders. We are now more aware and hopefully more sensitive to the struggles that individuals with mental health, mobility, and a range of other disabilities face *continuously*—with or without a pandemic.

Now is the time for a new normal: to *routinely* check up on each other's welfare, with *genuine* care and interest; embrace individuals *just as they are*; provide each individual with the support *that she or he needs*; and to reach out to individuals living temporary, *or on a constant basis*, with internal isolation or with restrictions.

The face mask phenomena reminds us of the many who constantly wear *mental or emotional* masks that make the significant struggles with which they live *invisible* to the onlooker. Peer beyond. Inquire. Reach out. Draw together as a community. Make people feel comfortable to share conditions and feelings. Make them feel understood. And supported—*where and how* the individuals need it most.

In the merit of our commitment to each other, may we witness the imminent arrival of the promised era of unmasked divinity and absolute harmony.

Shabbat Shalom!